A WRESTLING CARD GAME · 2 TO 6 PLAYERS · ABOUT 15 MINUTES

DOWN FOR THE COUNT

Every card in your hand is a move you can still make. Run out of moves and you tap out. Fail to answer too many times and the ref counts you out. Either way you're done for the round, and the last wrestler still on their feet wins it.

CONTENTS

60 cards: ranks 1 to 10, six of each. Print the seven card sheets (and the backs, if you like), cut along the crop marks, and you're ready.

SETUP

1. Shuffle. With 2 players, remove the 9s and 10s first.
2. Deal each player a **hand**, plus a row of face-down cards in front of them: your **count**. Don't look at your count.
3. With 2 or 3 players, set the rest of the deck aside for the round. With 4 or more, the whole deck is dealt.

PLAYERS	DECK	HAND	COUNT
2	1–8	13	3
3	1–10	15	3
4	1–10	12	3
5	1–10	10	2
6	1–10	8	2

Pick who opens the first round; after that, the previous round's winner opens. Arrange your hand however you like, whenever you like.

MOVES

You play cards in groups of **1 to 4** called **moves**:

- **Sets**: cards of the same rank. One card on its own is a set of 1.
- **Runs**: 2 to 4 cards in consecutive ranks, one of each.



A set of 2



A run of 3

ANSWERING A MOVE

To play on top of the move on the table, yours has to beat it. The first rule that applies decides:

1. **Bigger beats smaller.** More cards wins, whatever the type or rank.
2. **Same size: a set beats a run.** A pair beats a 2-run; three 6s beat 4-5-6.
3. **Same size and type: higher rank wins.** Runs compare by their top card.

> **5-5** is on the table: beat it with a higher pair, or any move of 3 or 4 cards. **5-6-7** is on the table: beat it with any three of a kind, a 3-run topping out on 8, 9 or 10, or any 4-card move.

YOUR TURN

If the table is empty, you **open**: play any move. You can't skip this.

Otherwise, do one of three things:

- **Play** a move that beats the one on the table.
- **Reversal**: take one card from the move on the table into your hand, and discard one of your count cards face down.
- **Kick out**: take one of your count cards into your hand. The move on the table stays.

A reversal or a kick out uses up a count: you survive, you're a card richer, and the ref is one count closer. **With 2 players there is no kick out.** If you can't beat the move, you reverse.

THE COUNT

Your face-down cards are your count. Every reversal and every kick out uses one up. Once they're gone, the next time you'd have to reverse or kick out, **you're pinned**: out of the round. A count card that comes into your hand is just a card. It never goes back.

If you play your last card and your hand is empty, you've **tapped out**: also out of the round. Pinned or tapped out, it's the same result.

REVERSALS

A reversal takes one card off the move on the table, and whatever's left must still be a legal move:

- From a **set**, take any one card. Four of a kind becomes three, a pair becomes a single.
- From a **run**, take either **end** card. A 4-run becomes a 3-run, a 2-run a single.
- Reversing a **single** clears the table. The next player opens.

WHEN YOUR MOVE COMES BACK

If the turn comes back around to you and the move on the table is still yours:

- **If it was reversed** (it's smaller than you played it), it's live. Beat it, reverse it or kick out, same as anyone.
- **If nobody touched it** (everyone kicked out), **take one card from it back into your hand** for free: any card from a set, an end card from a run. The next player then answers what's left. If that was the last card, the table clears and the next player opens.

If the player who played the current move is out, play continues against it as normal; once it has gone all the way around, the next player opens.

WINNING A ROUND

Wrestlers drop out one by one until a single player is left standing. They win the round.

PLAYING A MATCH

A match is **three rounds**. Each round, score by where you finished:

FINISH	POINTS
1st (last standing)	number of players
2nd	one less
…	…
first out	1

The winner of each round opens the next. Highest total after three rounds wins; tied players share the win.

RINGSIDE ADVICE

- **Your cards are your stamina.** Every card you play is one you can't play later. The minimum that beats the move is usually right.
- **The count is cheaper than it looks, until it isn't.** Each count buys a card. The one after your last is the pin.
- **Reverse when the card helps you; kick out when the move should stay scary** for the next player. But if everyone kicks out, the leader gets a card back for free.
- **Save the big one for when they're on the ropes.** A move nobody can answer is a finisher against a wrestler with no count left, and a gift against anyone else.
- **Watch the table.** Six of every rank exist. Count what's been played.

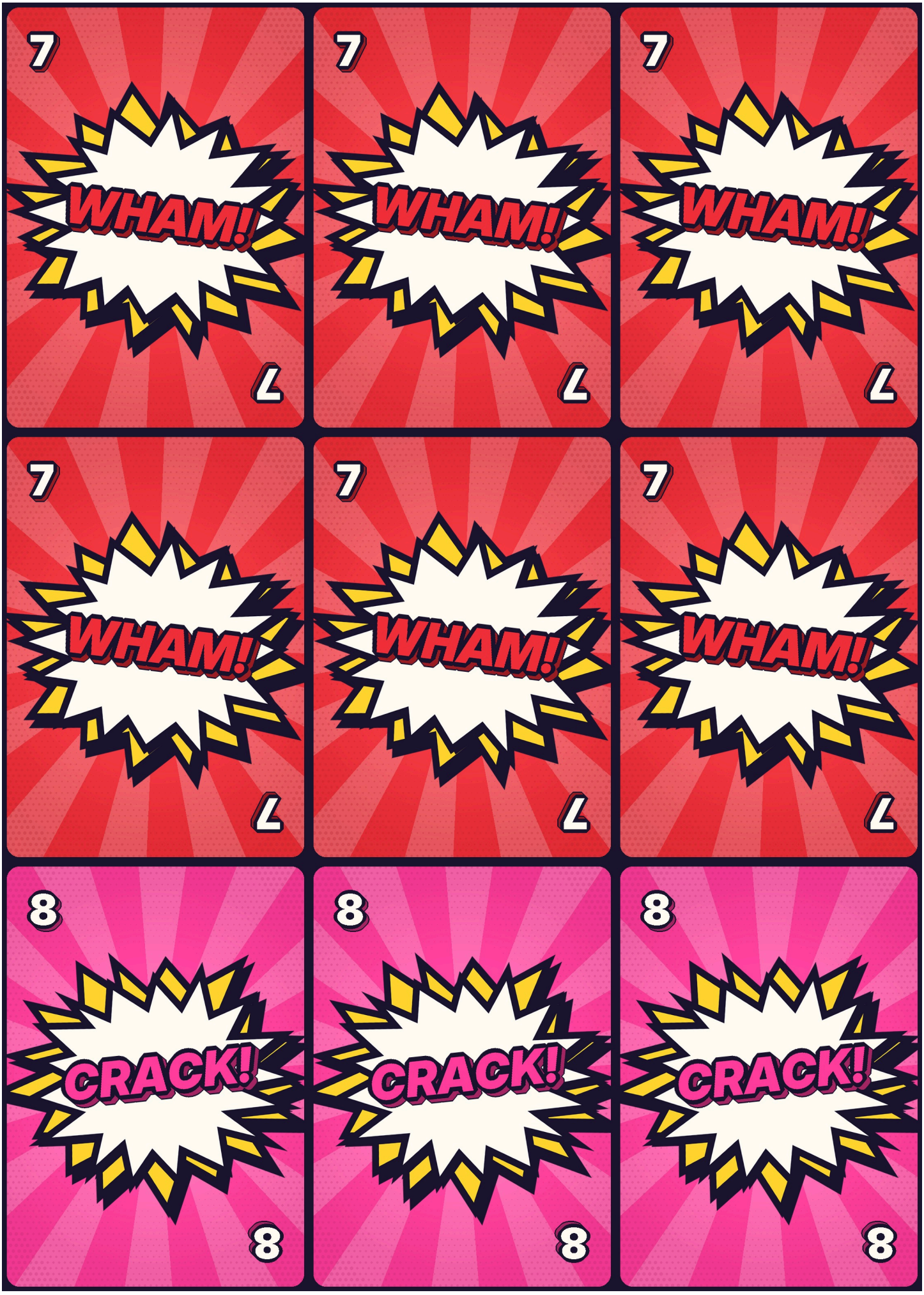
Play it in your browser against bots at **darrendon.github.io/games/down-for-the-count**

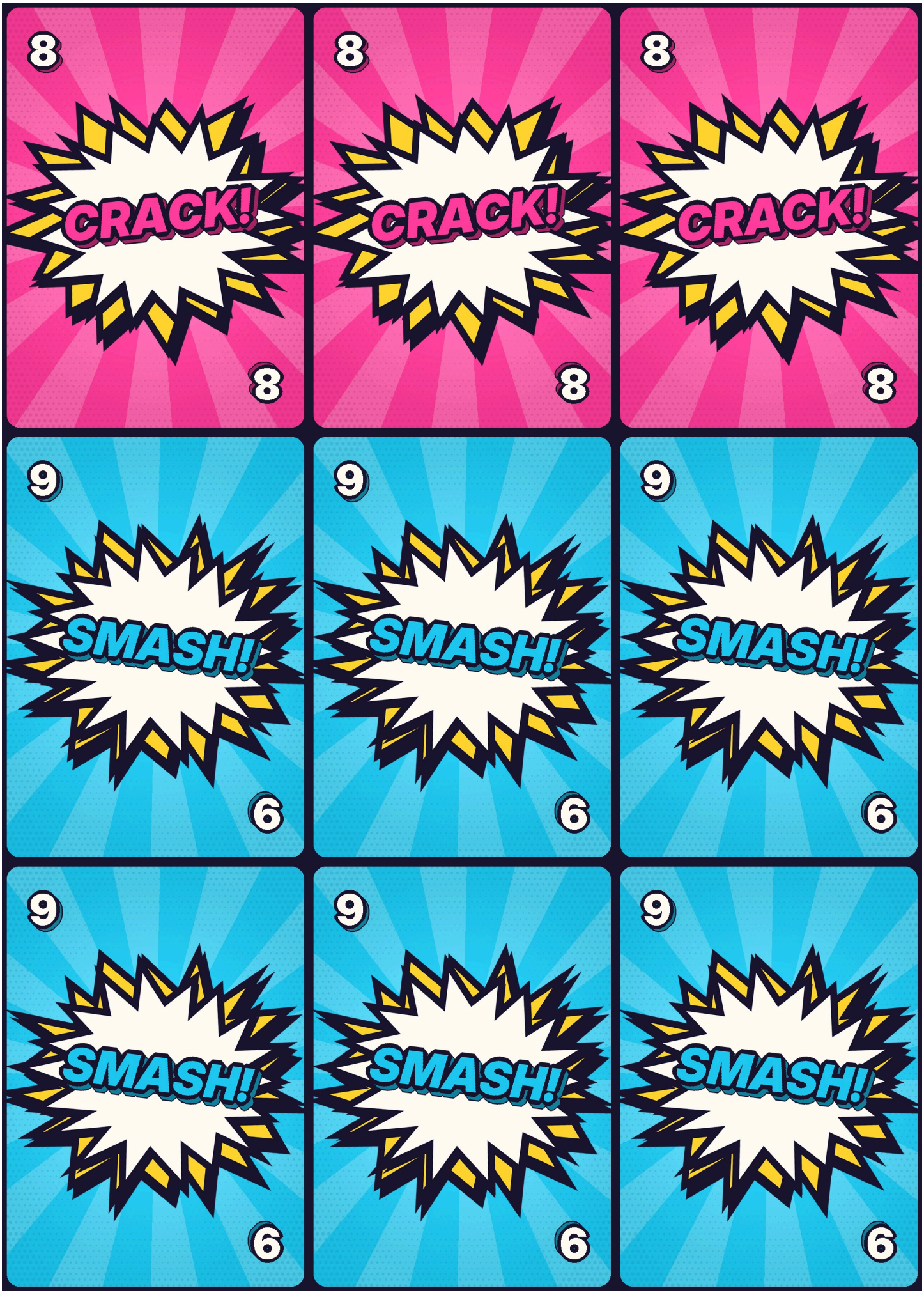

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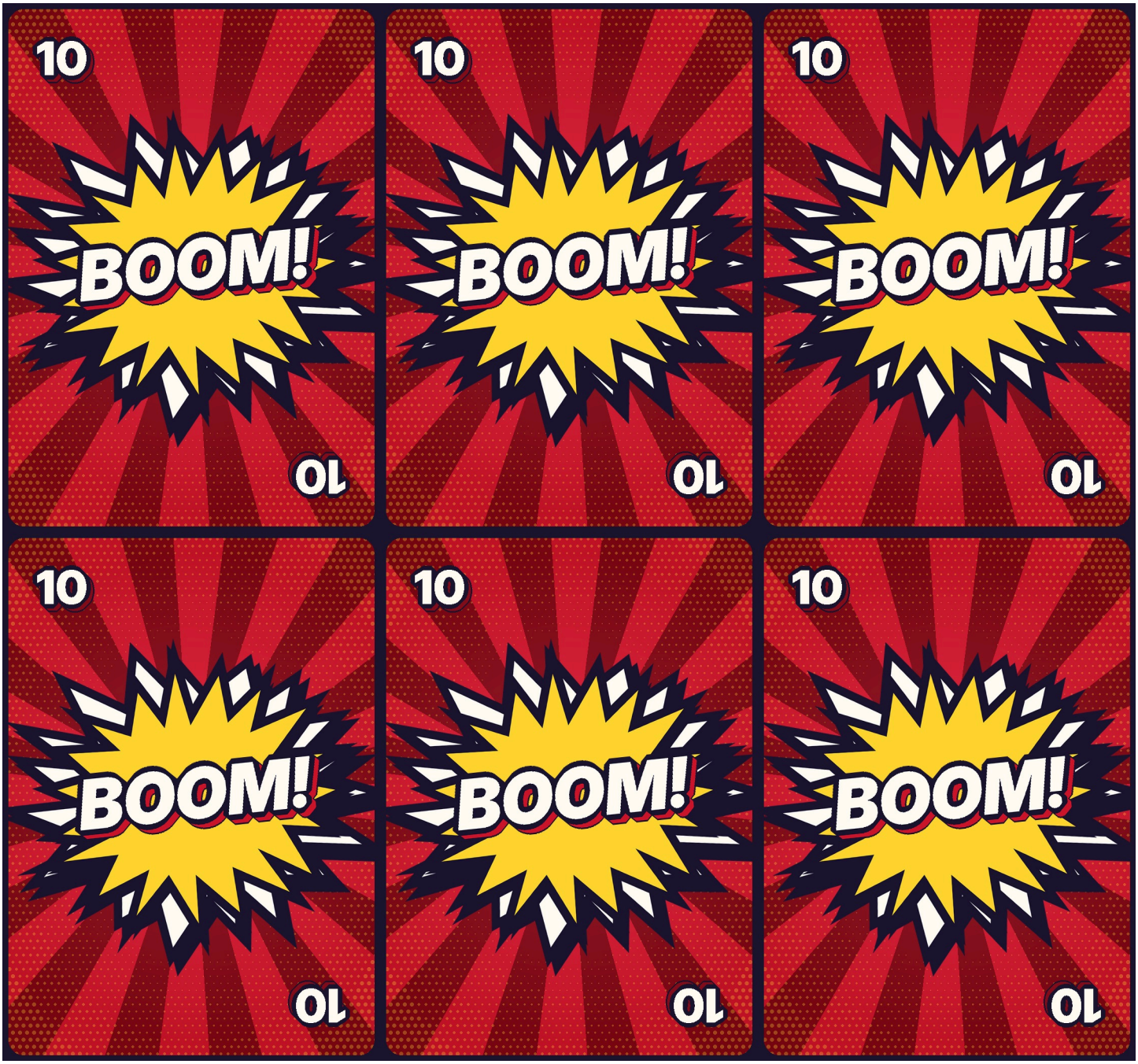

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OPTIONAL CARD BACKS · PRINT ON THE REVERSE OF EACH SHEET, FLIPPING ON THE LONG EDGE